

ARMED WITH DEGREES:
Bhati in Luni



At the Knowledge Junction

A railway vendor with nine degrees in his pocket shows how education can actually be an end in itself

■ **By Rohit Parihar**

At a small railway junction in Luni, 35 km from Jodhpur en route to Barmer, 42-year-old Ashok Kumar Bhati is a familiar figure. He has been selling delicacies, like rasgullas, from trolley No. 25 for the past 27 years at this junction. Nothing unusual about that. Just that Bhati, with a not-so-usual badge No. 786, is no ordinary vendor. For a man with a simple vocation, his educational qualifications are weighty and numerous. This vendor of sweets holds nine degrees and is still counting.

After graduating in commerce, Bhati did his Master's twice—in commerce and then in political science—and is now preparing to enroll for a PhD. He also holds an LLB degree, diplomas in labour laws and practice, taxation laws and practice, one in tourism and hotel management and a postgraduate diploma in human resource management. To top it all, he won a gold medal in mass communication from the Kota Open University in 1999.

On being asked why he was still selling wares on a railway platform despite such credentials, Bhati says, "I did take up a job after graduation, but was not able to sustain it for more than a week." With a Bachelor's degree in commerce, getting a job was easy, which happened all of 32



years back. He was recruited as a lower division clerk in a public sector bank. But the boredom of sorting out letters in the despatch section got the better of him and he quit the job, ignoring the advice and the warning of the officer accountant at the bank that he would regret his decision one day.

After all, the hum drum of a stale clerical job was nothing compared to the excitement of making a living on a crowded railway platform, full of people jostling for every inch of space. But to make sure that he didn't end up being just one of thousands of railway vendors, he kept up with his studies and went on to acquire numerous degrees. "I am the most educated railway vendor in the country," Bhati says with a flourish, hoping to find a place in a record book, somewhere some day.

He has inherited this vocation from his father and grandfather who too used to work on the railway platform. Bhati, M.COM LLB, is not ashamed of what he does. He is proud of his ancestral job, his only gripe being that the Railways has never cared to recognise his talent. "If they wanted, they could have found a better job for me," he says, calculating the position he would have been at, had he continued with his bank job. Not one to give up though, this railway vendor, who today owns three trolleys, is studying for a doctorate now.